

The power of the bowman
The reputation of the English longbowman grew significantly during the Hundred Years' War. At the battle of Najera in April 1367 *(above),* the bow again proved decisive as the English forces, led by Edward the Black Prince, routed dismounted Franco-Spanish troops. The broad-barbed iron arrowheads *(right)* were typical of those used in the 14th century. They could cause a deep, wide wound, and were difficult to extract, but were not ideal for penetrating armour.

THE LONGBOW has been accurately described as "an ordinary wooden bow". Yet the outstanding skill of English and Welsh archers transformed this rather primitive weapon into a decisive battle-winning technology. It became the key to the military power of English kings in the 14th and 15th centuries, allowing them to defeat "the flower of French chivalry" at Crécy, Poitiers, and Agincourt. The archers were recognized as an elite force, although without the social status to match their importance to the English crown.

The effective use of massed archers armed with longbows emerged during warfare in Britain in the late 13th and early 14th centuries. Some historians have asserted that the English learned the power of the longbow from the Welsh, who allegedly employed it to deadly effect against the armies of Edward I (reigned 1271–1307). Although this theory is disputed, southern Wales was certainly an area where archery flourished. Both Welsh and English longbowmen were present in Edward's army when he defeated the Scots at Falkirk in 1298. But true credit for developing the effective deployment of archers as a source of mass firepower must be accorded to Edward III (reigned 1327–77). Fighting the Scots at Halidon Hill in 1333, he made the English knights fight dismounted with bodies of longbowmen positioned on their flanks. Chroniclers tell us that arrows flew "as thick as motes in a sunbeam". According to one contemporary source, the Scots "were able to sustain neither the force of archers, nor the arms of the knights"; another source tells us simply that the Scots "were beaten by the English archers". After this success, Edward and his successors went on to deploy massed bowmen in a series of wars against French kings between 1337 and 1453, known conventionally as the Hundred Years' War.

MASS AND SKILL

The great advantage of the longbow compared with the crossbow – a considerably more powerful and complex weapon – was its far greater rate of shot. An experienced archer was expected to shoot around 12 arrows a minute, if he was only required to aim in the general direction of the enemy. The English sought to put thousands of archers in the field. By the 15th century there were at least three bowmen to every one knight in the English army, and the ratio may have risen at times to ten to one. Collectively this mass of archers would deluge the enemy in a dense shower of arrows almost comparable to modern machine-gun fire. At the battle of Agincourt in 1415, it is thought that the English longbowmen may have had the capacity to loose 60,000 arrows a minute.

A medieval state inevitably found it a challenge to supply weaponry and ammunition on such a scale. In 1341 Edward III scoured his kingdom to collect 7,700 bows and 130,000 sheaves of arrows, which were then stored in the Tower of London and other armouries. It was said that in the 1350s not an arrow was to be found in the whole of England, since the king had taken them all for his campaign in France.

The problem of supplying bows and arrows was nothing, however, compared with the difficulty of assembling sufficient numbers of archers. Shooting a longbow was a specialist skill, requiring lifelong practice – boys typically learned the use of the bow from the age of seven. The archer had to develop considerable physical strength. Archers' skeletons of the period have been found with deformed left arms and shoulder bones, and badly twisted vertebrae, as a result of the repeated effort of drawing the 1.8m (6ft) bow. Aware of the need to maintain a pool of bowmen from whom the best could be selected for service, the English monarchy took active steps to encourage the practice of archery.



BARBED ARROWHEADS